- **If you are hospitalized when your enrollment begins**

We pay for covered services from the effective date of your enrollment. However, if you are in the hospital when your enrollment in our Plan begins, call our Customer Care department immediately at 800-821-6136. If you are new to the FEHB Program, we will reimburse you for your covered services while you are in the hospital beginning on the effective date of your coverage.

If you changed from another FEHB plan to us, your former plan will pay for the hospital stay until:

- You are discharged, not merely moved to an alternative care center;
- The day your benefits from your former plan run out; or
- The 92nd day after you become a member of this Plan, whichever happens first.

These provisions apply only to the benefits of the hospitalized person. If your plan terminates participation in the FEHB in whole or in part, or if OPM orders an enrollment change, this continuation of coverage provision does not apply. In such cases, the hospitalized person's benefits under the new plan begin on the effective date of enrollment.

You need prior Plan approval for certain services

The pre-service claim approval processes for inpatient hospital admissions (called precertification) and for other services, are detailed in this Section. A **pre-service claim** is any claim, in whole or in part, that requires approval from us in advance of obtaining medical care or services. In other words, a pre-service claim for benefits (1) requires precertification, prior approval or a referral and (2) will result in a reduction of benefits if you do not obtain precertification, prior approval or a referral.

- **Inpatient facility admission**

Precertification is the process by which – prior to your inpatient admission – we evaluate the medical necessity of your proposed stay, the location in which services are intended to be rendered, and the number of days required to treat your condition. Unless we are misled by the information given to us, we won't change our decision on medical necessity.

In most cases, your physician or facility will take care of requesting precertification. Because you are still responsible for ensuring that your care is precertified, you should always ask your physician or facility whether or not they have contacted us.

Avoid paying providers for services prior to precertification. It is important to assure services are authorized by a covered provider or facility.

We only cover a private room if we determine it to be medically necessary. Otherwise, we will pay the hospital's average charge for semi-private accommodations. The remaining balance is not a covered expense. If the hospital only has private rooms, we will cover the private room rate.

- **Warning**

You must get precertification for certain services prior to admission. Failure to do so will result in the following penalties:

- **In-network:**
  - We will reduce our benefits for the Inpatient Hospital, Long-Term Acute Care, Residential Treatment Center (RTC), Skilled Nursing Facility (SNF), or Rehabilitation Facility stay by $500 if precertification is not obtained prior to admission. If the stay is not medically necessary, we will only pay for any covered medical services and supplies that are otherwise payable on an outpatient basis.
- **Out-of-network:**
  - We will reduce our benefits for the Inpatient Hospital, Long-Term Acute Care, Residential Treatment Center (RTC), Skilled Nursing Facility (SNF), or Rehabilitation Facility stay by $500 per day for each day that is not precertified prior to admission. If the stay is not medically necessary, we will only pay for any covered medical services and supplies that are otherwise payable on an outpatient basis.